



Projecting the Archive: Bryan Forbes at 100

King Rat

King Rat

Directed by: Bryan Forbes

©: Columbia Pictures Corp.

Presented by: Columbia Pictures Corporation

A Coleytown Production

Produced by: James Woolf

Associate Producer: Marvin Miller

Assistant Director: Russell Saunders

Script Girl: Marie Kenney

Written for the Screen by: Bryan Forbes

Based on a novel by: James Clavell

Director of Photography: Burnett Guffey

Camera Operator: Andy McIntyre

Editor: Walter Thompson

Art Director: Robert Smith

Set Decorator: Frank Tuttle

Make-up Supervisor: Ben Lane

Music Composed and Conducted by: John Barry

Sound Supervisor: Charles J. Rice

Sound: James Z. Flaster, John Cox

Dubbing Editor: Roy Baker

Sound System: RCA Sound Recording

Cast:

The American Hut

George Segal (*Corporal King*)

Patrick O'Neal (*Max*)

Todd Armstrong (*Tex*)

Sammy Reese (*Kurt*)

Joseph Turkel (*Dino*)

Mike Stroka (*Miller*)

William Fawcett (*Steinmetz*)

Dick Johnson (*Pop*)

Hut 19

James Fox (*Flight Lieutenant Peter Marlowe*)

Denholm Elliott (*Larkin*)

Leonard Rossiter (*McCoy*)

John Standing (*Captain Dave*)

Hamilton Dyce (*the padre*)

Wright King (*Major Brough*)

John Ronane (*Captain Hawkins*)

Geoffrey Bayldon (*Vexley*)

John Levingston (*Myner*)

John Barclay (*Lieutenant Spence*)

David Frankham (*Cox*)

The Provost Staff

Tom Courtenay (*Lieutenant Robin Grey*)

David Haviland (*Masters*)

Roy Duane (*Peterson*)

The Senior Officers

John Mills (*Colonel George Smedley-Taylor*)

Gerald Sim (*Lieutenant Colonel Jones*)

Alan Webb (*Colonel Brant*)

John Merivale (*Colonel Foster*)

John Warburton (*the Commandant*)

The Hospital Staff

James Donald (*Dr Kennedy*)

Hedley Mattingly (*Dr Prodhomme*)

Michael Lees (*Stevens*)

The Australians

Reg Lye (*Tinker Bell*)

John Orchard (*Gurble*)

Larry Conroy (*Townsend*)

Arthur Malet (*Quartermaster Sergeant Blakeley*)

Edward Ashley (*Prouty*)

The Paratrooper

Richard Dawson (*Captain Weaver*)

The Japanese

Ishimoto (*Yoshima*) *The Japanese*

Teru Shimada (*General Shima*) *The Japanese*

Louis Neervort (*Torunami*) *The Japanese*

Anthony Faramus

+ intro by Sarah Standing, Bryan Forbes' daughter

Bryan Forbes on 'King Rat'

For an English director to make a film in Hollywood is a little like playing a Cup Final on an away ground. But everyone should taste the place once.

Otherwise, it would be like being a Roman Catholic and never seeing Rome.

As far as I, personally, am concerned, I'd always wanted to make a picture there. To me, Hollywood is the genesis of the film business. You go there to make pictures, just as you go to France to drink the best wines or to Africa to hunt the biggest game.

I'd been asked there several times, before, as a matter of fact, but the subject didn't fit. I never felt, for example, that I was really qualified to direct a Tennessee Williams story. But I had no such misgivings about *King Rat*. The basic commodities of the James Clavell novel about 10,000 Allied soldiers being squeezed by the Japanese during World War II into a Singapore jail built to hold 600 were just right.

The story we told in the film is very uncompromising, and intentionally so. For the primary concern is not escape but survival. In this respect, *King Rat* is quite unlike any other prisoner of war picture ever made. It is our hope that audiences, when viewing it, will get the impression that they are not looking at a movie but at reels of actual captured film.

To stress this illusion of reality, we cast the picture in almost every instance with young players whose faces are not yet too familiar on the screen, talented newcomers of the calibre of George Segal, Tom Courtenay and James Fox. As a matter of fact, we used only two 'name stars', John Mills and James Donald. And as they play comparatively small, cameo roles, we slipped them stealthily into the action so that their well-known, established personalities wouldn't blind anyone to the other performers.

Because Hollywood has changed considerably since the days of C. Aubrey Smith, when overnight almost any studio could field a cricket team, we had to import a good many of our supporting British players. Among others, they included Denholm Elliott, Alan Webb, Leonard Rossiter, Gerald Sim, Hamilton Dyce, Geoffrey Bayldon, David Watson, Reg Lye, Jack Merivale and John Ronane, and in their scenes with their American counterparts, Todd Armstrong, Patrick O'Neal, Joe Turkel, and the rest, they provided just the right accent we wanted.

With so many English actors needed for the cast it is probably reasonable to ask why the film was made in Hollywood, rather than abroad. The answer is quite simple. Had we elected to make it in England, we could have encountered problems with the weather.

We could have shot it in Singapore, of course. But that would have meant transporting a complete cast and crew there. And probably the extras, because it would have been impossible to find all the Caucasians we'd have needed to play prisoners.

But we couldn't have used the Changi jail for any of the scenes. Though still standing, the prison is now surrounded by a forest of television aerials. So there'd have been no real advantage in going there at all.

USA 1965
134 mins
35mm

A BFI National Archive print

Projecting the Archive: Bryan Forbes at 100

Forbes at 100 Symposium

Fri 4 Sep 11:30-17:00

Whistle Down the Wind + Q&A with actors

Hayley Mills, Diane Poole and Alan Barnes

Fri 4 Sep 18:15

The League of Gentlemen + intro by Mark Gatiss

Sun 6 Sep 14:40

Seance on a Wet Afternoon + intro by writer and
producer David McGillivray

Tue 8 Sep 18:00

The L-Shaped Room + intro by author and
journalist Cathi Unsworth

Tue 15 Sep 18:00

The Wrong Box + intro by Nanette Newman

Tue 22 Sep 18:15

King Rat + intro by Sarah Standing,

Bryan Forbes' daughter

Tue 29 Sep 18:00

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So, though I had some reservations at first, we settled on Hollywood, and I have to admit now that it turned out to be one of the happiest experiences of my professional life. Columbia gave me everything we wanted in the way of cast and crew, and they built on a ten-acre site in Thousand Oaks, about an hour's drive from the studio in Hollywood, the finest set I've ever seen.

Except for a few interior shots, we filmed the whole picture there, amid an atmosphere of camaraderie that is seldom obtainable on a sound stage. And our original fear of front office interference turned out to be a myth. We had complete artistic say-so on everything. In fact, we had nothing but help and welcome, from Mike Frankovich (Columbia's first Vice-President in charge of global productions) down to the last man, all the time we were there. I look forward to going back there again.

Production notes

A contemporary review

King Rat, which seemed on paper to be a quick combination of *Stalag 17* and *The Bridge on the River Kwai*, is something quite different on film – a touching and impressive experience. Bryan Forbes has put his sizeable talent for detail, in people as well as things, to work with a will and a fine cast supports him with the devotion such effort deserves but rarely gets.

My doubts about George Segal – born while watching *Ship of Fools* – were dispelled in the first ten minutes of *King Rat*. He seems to have as much potential as any young film actor working, in England or America. Given the right director, he can be looked for to produce tough, tempered performances like Newman's in *The Hustler*. James Fox is excellent as Segal's reluctant prodigy in the art of survival; he seems to relish the corruption that stalks his cinematic path. As for Tom Courtenay, it is unfortunate that his part is the weakest – at least in conception – in the film. After a strong beginning, Courtenay's compulsive policeman character fades in the harsh light of the relationship between Segal and Fox, and when he is rung in at the end for a final scene it seems the only touch of melodrama in a film that otherwise scrupulously avoids it.

Smaller parts are excellently sketched, as they have been in all of Forbes' films. James Donald, who has played more doctors than any actor this side of Raymond Massey, is at it again with his usual skilful understatement; Denholm Elliott has several effective moments as an officer who recognises a leader when he sees one; John Mills contributes two moving scenes as the camp commandant. And an American actor named Patrick O'Neal is beautifully weak as Segal's stooge; it is only when he is called upon to rebel that his work flounders.

The most impressive thing about *King Rat* is its honesty. You come away feeling that this is exactly what the everyday life in forced captivity must do to a man. Which way would I bend, you ask yourself – toward Segal's survival at any price or Courtenay's almost religious rigidity? Books are what usually make you ask yourself questions like this; that *King Rat* does as well is a measure of its quality.

Town, January 1966